

THE NIGERIAN Women's War

THE WAR OF 1929

▼ Racist rhetoric

This advertising trade card for a raincoat was made by UK firm Bryson Ltd, who described their product as "one of the best British possessions." Advertising of the imperial period reinforced ideas of racial superiority, depicting Africans as exotic or "uncivilized."

In 1929, women in Igboland, southeastern Nigeria, had had enough of their colonial oppressors. In the provinces of Calabar and Owerri, their unrest ignited a rebellion that came to be known as the Women's War of 1929. Colonial historians took a different view, referring to the event as a riot, but whatever it was called, the uprising was carried out on an unprecedented scale in Africa, and took colonial leaders by surprise. During the riots, 16 native courts were attacked and several European stores were looted. Out of 25,000 Igbo women activists, 55 were killed and over 50 were seriously injured.

Rebel causes

The two-month long rebellion was caused by a chain of circumstances, which started with Britain's policy of indirect rule over its colony through warrant chiefs—mostly Igbo chiefs appointed by the British governor. Over time, these warrant chiefs abused their power, mistreated women, and seized property and livestock for themselves. Traditionally, women were respected members of Igbo society who played a significant role in political life, but warrant chiefs blocked women from holding government positions. Women's dissatisfaction was compounded by economic hardship. Under British rule, the Igbo economy had begun to revolve around palm oil sales, and when prices fell in 1929, taxes stayed the same, putting a huge burden on Igbo women. An increase in school fees was followed by plans to impose direct British taxation on women (Igbo men had been taxed from 1928).

▼ Wrapped in tradition

This photograph shows Igbo women at the beginning of the 20th century. Their traditional wrappers are made of Akwete cloth, a textile woven by Igbo women throughout history.

